Modals: can, could, may (requests and permission)

Goal: To make requests, ask for permission and give or refuse permission politely using the modals can, could and may, choosing the right level of formality.

The idea in two lines: Can, could and may are modal verbs: they are followed by the base form and never take -s. "Can" is informal, "could" is more polite, and "may" is the most formal, especially for permission.

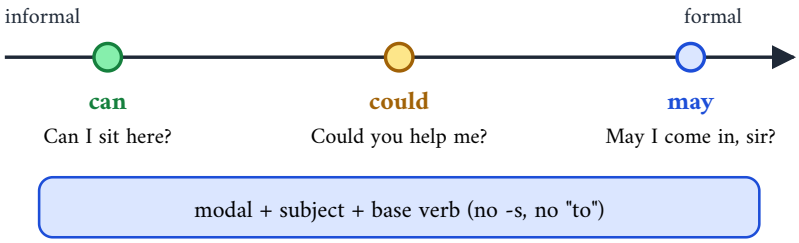


Figure 1: From informal to formal: can → could → may, all followed by the base verb.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form:** modal + base verb. The modal does not change with the subject: she can swim (not "she cans"). Questions are made by inversion: Can you...? Negatives add "not": cannot / can't, could not / couldn't, may not.
2. **Requests** (asking someone to do something): Can you open the window? Could you lend me your pen, please? "Could" is more polite than "can".
3. **Asking for permission** (asking if I am allowed): Can I use your phone? Could I leave early? May I ask a question? "May" is formal and respectful.
4. **Giving permission:** Yes, you can. / Yes, you may. / Of course. / Certainly.
5. **Refusing politely:** I'm afraid you can't. / No, you may not. / Sorry, but...
6. **Other meanings of can / could:** ability (I can drive) and possibility (It could rain).

🟢 Examples

1. A pupil wants to leave the classroom. He says to the headmaster: "... I go out, please?" **Answer:** May I go out, please? **Explanation:** the situation is formal and the pupil asks for permission → may.
2. You ask a friend to pass the salt. **Answer:** Can you pass the salt, please? **Explanation:** informal request to a friend → can ("could" is also correct).
3. Reply to "Could I borrow your dictionary?" with a refusal. **Answer:** I'm afraid you can't; I need it now. **Explanation:** a refusal is softened with "I'm afraid" and a reason.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Adding "to" after the modal: "Can I to go?" instead of "Can I go?"
- Adding -s to the modal or the verb: "He cans swim" / "Could she helps?"
- Using "do" with a modal: "Do you can help me?" instead of "Can you help me?"
- Mixing up request and permission: "Could you" asks someone to act; "Could I" asks for permission.

🟡 Quick review

- Modal + base verb; no -s, no "to", no "do".
- Request: Can / Could you + verb? Permission: Can / Could / May I + verb?
- can = informal, could = polite, may = formal.
- Answer with the same modal: Yes, you may. / No, you can't.
- Add "please" and a reason to be polite.

madrasadz.com ⁘ مدرسة ديزاد